

SILVER TONGUE Gujarat BJP president Jagdish Vishwakarma in Dang, Gujarat, Mar. 14

▶ GUJARAT

VISHWAKARMA RECRAFTS PARTY

Gujarat's new BJP chief is bringing his accessible style into play in a ground-up perestroika ahead of local polls

boxes sitting on the floor. At taluka party offices, he speaks to staff on local issues. He talks extensively about ideology too," says a senior leader of Vishwakarma's team at Shree Kamalam in Koba, Gandhinagar, the BJP state HQ.

Another leader draws a contrast with the previous regime, which he describes as "more authoritarian". Vishwakarma's style is methodical, yet more decentralised. Says a Kamalam veteran, "He has removed passive corruption and pressure tactics from candidate selection. Candidates now turn up alone to submit their papers—no retinues, no shows of strength. All meetings happen at party offices, not at MP, MLAs' bungalows or farmhouses. These small acts give cadres a message of sincerity."

Takeaways

- **His openness has changed candidate selection process**
- **Has toured all 32 districts, talking to ground workers**
- **Polls to 9,900 local bodies in April will be litmus test**

TRUE TO HIS ORIGINS

His own resume explains this. Vishwakarma entered the BJP as a booth-level worker at age 25 in Nikol, and rose to be a three-term MLA. But making the Gujarat BJP cohere is a tall ask: at 12.5 million members, a 150,000-strong active cadre, its footprint could fill countries. Like a flytrap, it also ingests rebels from rival parties. Vishwakarma is familiar with those cross-currents. As a minister till last October, three ex-Congressmen were cabinet ministers above him. Later, even ex-state Congress chief Arjun Modhwadia came in.

The phenomenon peaked in 2022, when the BJP replaced a fifth of its MLAs and fielded 17 Congress rebels. The ensuing ruckus, and the derisive slogan "Congress-yukt BJP", forced the high command into an unusual retreat: at least two faces had to be replaced. That became a footnote when the BJP won 156/182 seats, the highest ever for any party in Gujarat. Until 2023 and 2024, when six MLAs migrated in: four Congress, one AAP, one independent. All were rewarded with bypoll tickets. The AAP import lost his seat to his former party. The others won.

So, the old wounds were reopened. The other day, a veteran tore his application in front of the central observer, seeing the man sitting in judgement on his candidacy was an old Congressi. Routine friction, spokesman Prashant Vala calls it, presenting 'Jagdishbhai'—a listener more than an orator—as one who can soothe and water the grassroots. He sees the polls as just an engine check. The Congress and especially AAP, which is fighting all 9,900 seats, may disagree, but they won't have the benefit anymore of citing a BJP leadership aloof from the ground. ■